Youth: Emerging Subcultures 2025

From outdoor-focused Functionalists to emo-loving Subversive Romantics, discover five subcultures to know for 2025, and the aesthetic and cultural references that will resonate most with them

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Executive summary

In recent years, young people have gathered around movements defined by shared aesthetics. Come 2025, more young people will be drawn to movements characterised by shared values and community.

Opportunity

Identifying and understanding subcultures offers an opportunity for brands to differentiate themselves at a time of mass marketing. As niche becomes the norm and multiple subcultures and lifestyles surface into the mainstream, it's more important than ever for brands to cut through the noise and access communities. This report identifies five emerging subcultures you need to know, and also outlines two distinct directions (known as trend tensions) for each, as culture becomes more fractured and trends move faster. Some of these subcultures call to mind youth movements from earlier decades, but they are more fluid and less rigidly tied to place or background, in keeping with Gen Z's focus on diversity, equity and inclusion.

Need to know:

- While words like “subculture” and “aesthetic” have become marketing buzzwords, it's important to establish the difference. An **aesthetic** is an interchangeable set of visual codes that signify an association or affiliation with a specific trend or style group. A **subculture** is a community bonded through shared lifestyles, belief systems and attitudes, which are communicated to others through visual cues.
- A global report found that Gen Zers spend 16 hours weekly engaging in fan communities. The same report found that 63% of Gen Z say fandoms enable them to express their identity and creativity
- 92% of US Gen Z say a brand’s community will influence their perception of the company

Key profiles

- **The Subversive Romantics:** this subcultural group is influenced by fashion, beauty and music from the 1990s emo and grunge scene
- **The Chaotic Curators:** these risk-takers express themselves via bold statements, bad taste and kitsch styles of dress
- **The Functionalists:** drive hype among this group of outdoor enthusiasts by launching exclusive streetwear and IYKYK (if you know, you know) merch
- **The Legacists:** this preppy and collegiate-inspired group gravitates towards heritage and draws inspiration from sports (especially tennis, golf and rugby)
- **The Reverie Escapists:** emerging from the cottagecore aesthetic ecosystem, this subculture remixes folklore and myths with hyper-feminine styles of dress and ethereal vibes

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Relevant industries: fashion, beauty, lifestyle, interiors, entertainment

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The Subversive Romantics

This subcultural group expresses their deep emotions of sadness, longing, anger and rage through dark music genres, and draws fashion and beauty inspiration from the 1990s emo and grunge scene.

Strategy: empower Subversive Romantics to explore their identity and expression through the DIY economy, from temporary hair dye to customising clothing and accessories. Prioritise diversity and inclusion by teaming up with creators from different backgrounds to reimagine emo and punk scenes that are representative of their identities and backgrounds.

In action:

- Marc Jacobs' youth label Heaven partnered with Good Dye Young, the hair dye brand of Hayley Williams (lead singer of emo rock band Paramore), for its spring 2024 campaign. The imagery featured punk references and styling, from make-up and hair colours to the accessories
- Emerging South African brand Afrogrunge is gaining ground for its rebellious spirit in the nation. Founded by designer and creative Anita Hlazo, she celebrates and fuses African heritage with grunge aesthetics
- Shoegaze music is becoming popular among youth globally as its melancholic sound resonates during a difficult time. The Eurocentric music genre is finding its way into the Chinese music landscape, with bands like Shanghai's Pale Air and Guangzhou's Jo's Moving Day

Beauty Feed hashtags: #Blackout, #PunkArmy, #Gothica, #SoftGrunge

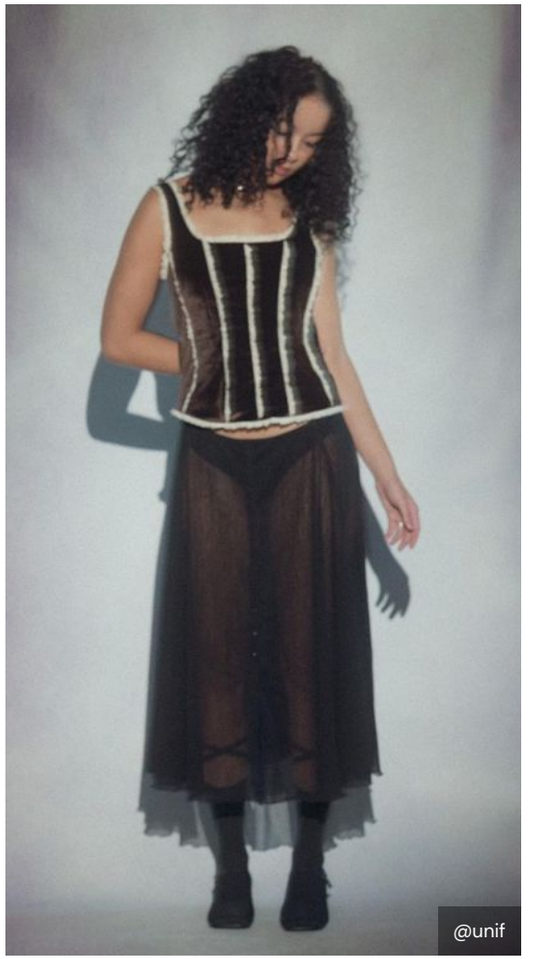
Fashion Feed hashtags: #ModernGoth, #DarkRomance, #PopPunk, #90sGrunge

Related aesthetics: goth, punk, emo, scene, visual kei, horror

Context: this community is influenced by emo, punk and grunge, which were once distinct subcultures. Trend tensions will exist among this group, culminating in two different subgroups: angst-driven dark nihilists and the softer, more feminine aesthetics of dark romantics.



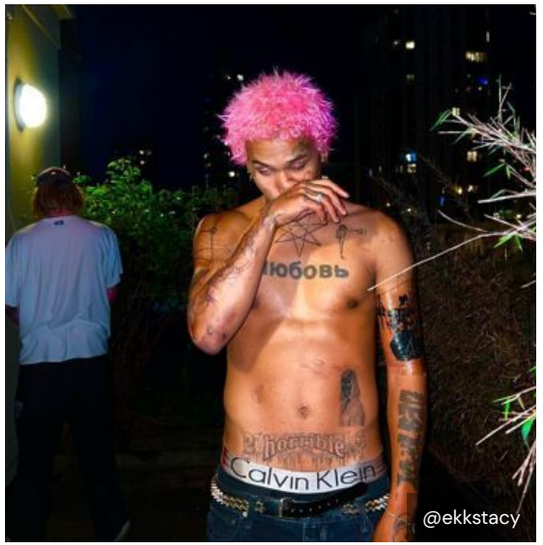
Dark nihilists lean towards teen angst, with consumers listening to pop-punk and alternative rock music. They dress more casually, with a strong 1990s influence



Dark romantics explore a softer side to the subculture, dressing in more feminine ways and gravitating towards genres such as emo-pop, shoegaze and indie rock

Subcultural references: The Subversive Romantics









The Chaotic Curators

The Chaotic Curators are risk-takers when it comes to expressing their identity through their personal style, often mixing clashing prints, colours, textures and patterns.

Strategy: be playful and bold when marketing or selling to this group and be sure to follow kidult lifestyles. Playful experiences and messages resonate well with this group, as 51% of LATAM Gen Z and 59% of APAC Gen Z are willing to purchase from brands that embrace humour and play. For beauty and interior brands, embrace bad taste and pair it with surreal and kitsch designs to align with this cohort's aesthetic and visual identity.

In action:

- Independent e-commerce site APOC Store onboarded nail artists as part of its roster of creatives. It enlisted nine artists – Cyshimi, Raw Nails, Texto Dallas, Sammy Does, Dinara Garaeva, Hot Nails, Doux Nails, Räthel & Wolf and Soji Nails – known for their surreal, bold and avant-garde DIY art
- IKEA partnered with Raw Color, a Netherlands-based design agency, to launch an 18-piece collection featuring textiles, furniture and decor in bold colours, textures and patterns
- Japanese street-style Instagrammer @aoki_street.1985 aims to document young people who are driving Harajuku and Decora Kei fashion

Beauty Feed hashtags: #NailSculptures, #JoyfulExpression, #DopamineBrights

Fashion Feed hashtags: #Kidult, #JoyfulExpression, #MainCharacterEnergy, #PrettyExtravaganza

Related aesthetics: Decora Kei, kawaii, fairy kei, Harajuku street

Context: come 2025, surrealism will be a key driver in marketing and will accelerate the rise of this subculture. This community will explore obscure, abstract and quirky looks, taking inspiration from Japanese Harajuku street style and the cuteness movement (experimental hair, nails and motifs that reference anime and cartoons). Trend tensions will cause two sub-aesthetic styles to bubble up: bad taste and hyper-feminine styles



Bad taste is a more chaotic approach to the subculture, featuring mismatched looks with clashing colours and loud prints and patterns



Hyper-feminine looks within the subculture will see the use of lighter fabrics and colours, and make-up that is subtly surreal

Subcultural references: The Chaotic Curators











WGSN

The Functionalists

This cohort gravitates to IYKYK merch and collaborations between outdoor brands and streetwear, and they will be more driven by hype.

Strategy: partner with key outdoor players like Snowpeak and ROA Hiking to host events such as group hikes and community workshops to drive engagement; 81% of 13- to 39-year-olds in the US, Canada and Europe are interested in trips that bring them closer to nature. Niche merch collabs can drive social capital hype for fashion-forward Functionalists as they like the thrill of discovering new independent brands and collecting exclusive merch.

In action:

- London-based outdoor retailer Outsiders Store partnered with Japanese outdoor brand Snowpeak to host an outdoor weekend filled with workshops and events. It will also feature activities hosted by other outdoor brands like and wander, Helinox, Greater Goods and Arc'teryx
- Korean label OJOS is a contemporary brand that creates urban outdoorwear. It features minimalist and multifunctional designs that are made using nylon, which is commonly used to create outdoor gear
- Sports and activewear brand ASICS has an ongoing partnership with Bulgarian fashion designer Kiko Kostadinov. The duo recently launched a new pair of sneakers which have become archival collectibles

Beauty Feed hashtags: #AthBeauty, #OutdoorBeauty, #MultifunctionalBeauty, #OnTheGoBeauty

Fashion Feed hashtags: #UtilityDetails, #TheGreatOutdoors, #ElevatedOutdoors, #FutureUtility

Related aesthetics: streetwear, utilitarian, gorpcore, techwear, hikecore

Context: the Functionalists participate in outdoor activities like camping, hiking, running foraging and climbing. As they prioritise outdoor community engagement and immersing themselves in nature, they put self-care and wellness routines at the forefront of their lifestyles. The trend tension will lead to two style types: traditional outdoor and fashion-focused



Traditional outdoor Functionalists prioritise utility and practicality over the hype around a brand. They invest in high-quality pieces that allow them to perform well outdoors



Fashion-forward Functionalists opt for IYKYK merch and collaborations between outdoor brands and streetwear. They participate in community-focused outdoor activities

Subcultural references: The Functionalists









The Legacists

Play into the collegiate lifestyles by partnering with heritage brands or sports labels to launch campaigns and collections.

Strategy: leverage brand fiction as a marketing and retail tool to develop fictional storylines, helping brands to level up their entertainment value and create a strong narrative around collegiate lifestyles.

In action:

- In light of its 100th anniversary, Belstaff, a British heritage brand, collaborated with students from the Manchester Fashion Institute to reimagine its heritage collection. The brand partnered with six female fashion students to redesign its iconic motorcycle jacket
- Rapper Tyler, the Creator's brand GOLF le FLEUR plays into preppy aesthetics through its collections and branding. It puts a playful spin on traditional prep through the use of bright and pastel colours with bold graphics
- London-based menswear label Drake's partnered with New York label Aimé Leon Dore to unveil a collection of tailored pieces. The five-look capsule collection featured British-inspired preppy looks, with pinstriped wool suits and printed scarves

Beauty Feed hashtags: #MultifunctionalBeauty

Fashion Feed hashtags: #OutOfRetirement, #ModernAcademia, #SmartenUp, #GentleRetro

Related aesthetics: preppy, varsity, 70s, nautical

Context: the Legacists turn to thrifting and re-commerce for fashion items from heritage brands like Burberry and Lacoste, while also searching for vintage items that are inspired by the 1970s, prep and Americana. They keep their beauty routines and looks fuss-free, opting for natural looks. Trend tensions for this group lead to sportswear prep and heritage prep styles



Heritage prep involves more tailored and smart-casual looks, such as mixing blazers with sweatshirts or caps with trench coats



Sportswear prep focuses more on athletic and varsity-inspired ways of dress, mixing jerseys and knee-high socks as part of everyday dress

Subcultural references: The Legacists









The Reverie Escapists

Play into girlhood and feminine aesthetics and combine that with myths and folklore to capture this community of consumers.

Strategy: as 2025 is the year that strategic imagination will hit mass, brands should employ world-building as a tool to create whimsical, spiritual and folklore-driven narratives in campaigns that engage this cohort. Consider also making their music idols the face of campaigns. This subculture has active members of fandoms within music genres such as dream pop, indie and avant-pop, favouring artists such as Grimes, FKA Twigs, Lana Del Rey and Solange.

In action:

- Singaporean brand byCaxs empowers young Southeast Asian women to experiment and challenge traditional beauty standards by embracing ethereal looks through coloured lenses and glittery make-up kits
- For Valentine's Day, underwear brand SKIMS featured indie pop artist Lana Del Rey as the face of its campaign. The partnership drove hype and the campaign generated $13.7m in media exposure in four days
- London-based fragrance brand Vyrao references spirituality in its messaging. Each perfume comes with an affirmation for the wearer to say while spraying. Every scent is also crafted to help balance specific chakras

Beauty Feed hashtags: #CelestialGlow, #SweetPastel, #Futuristic

Fashion Feed hashtags: #DustedPastels, #PrettyExtravaganza, #NuHistorics

Related aesthetics: fairycore, auroracore, cottagecore, Art Nouveau

Context: This subculture embraces the codes of hyper-femininity. The trend tension will give rise to darker fantasy looks and ethereal fairytale aesthetics.



Dark fantasy is heavily influenced by witchcraft, magic and the occult



Ethereal fairytale is a lighter aesthetic that is more associated with fairies, nature and flowers, similar to cottagecore

Subcultural references: The Reverie Escapists

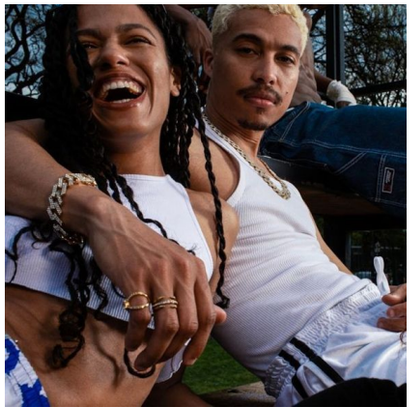








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